

JSS 1 CULTURAL AND CREATIVE ARTS

FIRST TERM

TOPIC 1: INTRODUCTION TO ARTS

1. Meaning and Definitions of Arts

Art is the expression or application of human creative skill and imagination, typically in a visual form such as painting, drawing, sculpture, or in other forms like music, dance and drama, producing works to be appreciated for their beauty or emotional power.

Other simple definitions:

- Art is the ability to create beautiful or meaningful things using skill and imagination.
- Art is a way of communicating ideas, feelings and experiences through visual, auditory or performance media.
- Art is the product of human creativity that appeals to the senses and emotions.

2. History and Origin of Arts

Art is as old as humanity itself. The earliest forms of art were created by prehistoric people thousands of years ago.

Prehistoric Art:

Early humans painted on cave walls (cave paintings) in places like Lascaux in France and Altamira in Spain. They drew animals, hunting scenes and human figures using natural pigments (ochre, charcoal). These paintings are over 15,000–40,000 years old.

Ancient Civilisations:

Great civilisations developed sophisticated art: Egyptian art (pyramids, hieroglyphs, sculptures), Greek and Roman art (statues, architecture), Chinese and Indian art, and African traditional art (masks, sculptures, pottery).

Art in Traditional African / Nigerian Societies:

Long before colonial times, Nigerian peoples created rich art forms – Nok terracotta sculptures, Ife and Benin bronze and terracotta works, Igbo-Ukwu metal works, Yoruba wood carvings, Hausa leatherwork and embroidery, and many others. Art was used for religion, royalty, festivals and daily life.

3. How Arts Started in Nigerian Schools

Formal art education in Nigerian schools began during the colonial period. Missionaries and colonial administrators introduced Western-style art (drawing, painting) into the school curriculum.

- Early art teachers were often missionaries or European educators.
- Later, Nigerian artists and educators such as Aina Onabolu championed the teaching of art in schools and the recognition of African art.
- After independence, the Nigerian government included Cultural and Creative Arts (CCA) in the national curriculum to promote creativity, cultural awareness and national identity.
- Today, CCA is a core subject in Junior Secondary Schools under the NERDC curriculum.

4. Branches / Types of Arts

Art is broadly divided into the following major branches:

a) Visual Arts (Fine Arts)

Arts that can be seen. They include:

- Drawing and Painting
- Sculpture (carving, modelling, casting)
- Graphics / Graphic Design
- Textiles (weaving, dyeing, printing)
- Ceramics / Pottery
- Photography

b) Performing Arts

Arts that involve performance before an audience:

- Music (vocal and instrumental)
- Dance
- Drama / Theatre

c) Literary Arts

Arts expressed through written or spoken words: poetry, prose, storytelling, playwriting.

d) Applied / Industrial Arts

Arts applied to practical or commercial purposes: fashion design, interior decoration, industrial design, architecture.

5. Uses of Arts in Society

Art plays many important roles in society:

- **Communication** – Art conveys messages, ideas and emotions without words.
- **Decoration and Beautification** – Homes, public places and clothing are made beautiful through art.
- **Cultural Preservation** – Art records and preserves the history, values and traditions of a people.
- **Religion and Ritual** – Masks, sculptures and music are used in worship and festivals.
- **Education** – Art teaches history, morals and social values.
- **Entertainment** – Music, dance and drama provide leisure and enjoyment.
- **Economic Value** – Artists earn a living; art works are sold and exported.
- **Therapy and Healing** – Art is used to reduce stress and help people express feelings.
- **National Identity and Unity** – Art promotes pride in culture and brings people together.

6. Summary

Art is the creative expression of human skill and imagination. It has existed since prehistoric times and is deeply rooted in Nigerian traditional societies. In schools, art education helps students develop creativity and cultural awareness. Art is divided into visual, performing, literary and applied arts, and it serves important social, cultural, economic and educational purposes.

End of Topic 1 – Introduction to Arts